

LEAP OF INSIGHT: CONFRONTING IMPUNITY IN ETHIOPIA

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY AND CALL TO ACTION

The pilot monitoring report prepared by OJAH reveals persistent, widespread human rights violations in Ethiopia's Amhara and Tigray regions from January to June 2025. Parallel to several government initiatives which repeatedly fail to bear fruit, atrocities, such as extrajudicial killings, airstrikes, arbitrary detentions, and sexual violence continue unabated, with the Ethiopian government implicated in half of all documented incidents. vulnerable members of the population, including women, children, and the elderly bear the greatest burden while human rights defenders face targeted repression. OJAH urgently calls for unified action by civil society, international support for human rights organizations, and respect for due process by Ethiopian security forces to end impunity and foster justice and accountability.

URGENT CALL TO ACTION

1. **Human Rights Advocacy Organizations and Civil Society:** OJAH calls upon all organizations working to ensure justice and accountability in Ethiopia to unify their efforts through a Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations to create a coordinated, victim-centered transitional justice process, and actively follow all feasible legal avenues to secure accountability.
2. **International Community:** OJAH calls upon all international communities and partners to provide technical and financial support towards the formation of the Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations and reinforce its efforts by imposing targeted sanctions on perpetrators of human rights violations, making diplomatic engagement and non-humanitarian aid conditional on tangible improvements in human rights in Ethiopia.
3. **Ethiopian Justice and Security Institutions and Perpetrators of Violence:** OJAH calls upon law enforcements institutions inside Ethiopia to respect due process, and all perpetrators of violence to cease violating human rights.

THE REPORT

This report presents the findings of a pilot project conducted by OJAH with the technical and financial support of the Open Society Foundation (OSF). The project monitored and analyzed conflict-related human rights violations in Ethiopia's high-risk Amhara and Tigray regions from January 1 to June 30, 2025.

CONTEXT: THE RECURRENT STILLBIRTH OF JUSTICE AND ACCOUNTABILITY

The Ethiopian Government, in addition to engaging with international bodies and frameworks such as the African Union, has announced multiple initiatives over the past seven years aimed at justice and accountability.

These include the establishment of the Ethiopian Reconciliation Commission in 2018, the Joint Declaration of Peace and Friendship with Eritrea the same year, judicial reforms and special courts launched post-2018, the Pretoria Agreement in 2022, the Northern Ethiopia Task Force and regional reconciliation efforts also in 2022, the adoption of a Transitional Justice Policy in 2023, and the creation of the National Dialogue Commission in 2024. Despite these initiatives, the cycle of atrocities in the country has intensified during this period. The ongoing absence of meaningful justice and accountability has left millions of Ethiopians exposed to continuing violations without redress, indicating that these efforts have yet to yield substantial progress on the ground. This apparent stalling justice and accountability allows the government to avoid rigorous international scrutiny, perpetuating a dangerous climate of impunity.

This situation not only fails to address the severity of past violations but also neglects the government's fundamental responsibility to prevent future atrocities. The persistent conflicts in Amhara and Tigray, marked by severe human rights abuses, clearly show that current policies have been unable to secure peace, stability, or justice. This pilot project takes an important step toward addressing this ongoing impunity by generating real-time, verifiable evidence intended to support and strengthen advocacy and accountability efforts.

METHOD

- Documentation efforts: The data rely on human intelligence, open-source documentation, and media monitoring, all subjected to a rigorous, multi-layered verification process.
- Ethical Standard: OJAH operates under a strict "do no harm" principle, prioritizing the confidentiality and security of survivors and sources at all times, in accordance with international best practice.

OPERATIONAL LIMITATIONS

The pilot project helped identify critical operational challenges inherent to monitoring in conflict zones:

- Information Environment: Inconsistent internet and communication blackouts routinely delay incident recording and submission, especially in the Amhara region where an internal conflict has been ongoing since April 2023.
- Security Risks: Local documenters face extreme danger, making information access and verification difficult in conflict zones.
- Impunity Reflected in Data: The overwhelming proportion of incidents that remain uninvestigated (73.08%, i.e., 38 incidents out of the total 52) starkly illustrates the depth of the impunity challenge, where documentation itself is a high-risk endeavor.

FINDINGS: PATTERNS OF SYSTEMATIC VIOLENCE

OVERVIEW OF INCIDENTS

- Total of 52 incidents recorded and analyzed by OJAH, providing a snapshot of the human rights landscape.
- In Tigray: A total of 18 (34.61%) incidents were recorded. Incidents from January (3) through April (6), peaking in April, then declining to May (1) and June (1).
- In Amhara: A total of 34 (65.38%) incidents were recorded. Escalation from no incidents in January, modest in February (4) and March (2), surging to April (5), May (15), and slight decrease in June (9).

Takeaway: *Incidents of atrocities appear to be shifting in location but show no sign of abating, indicating ongoing conflict and human rights violations across the regions.*

TYPES OF VIOLATIONS BY REGION AND FORMS OF IMPACT

- Extrajudicial, summary or arbitrary killing (32.69%, 17 incidents), mostly in Amhara (16), causing civilian fatalities.
- Airstrike (11.54%, 6 incidents), exclusively in Amhara, causing civilian casualties and property destruction.
- Sexual Violence (1.92%, 1 incident in Tigray), causing physical harm and psychological trauma.
- Armed Clashes (13.46%, 7 incidents), causing fatalities and injuries (5 in Amhara, 2 in Tigray).
- Violations of liberty, including abductions/disappearances (9.62%, 5 incidents, all in Tigray), arbitrary arrests/detention & Related Abuses (17.31%, 9 incidents, 5 in Amhara, 4 in Tigray), involving unlawful detentions and ill-treatment.
- Other violations (13.46%, 7 incidents), more in Tigray (5 vs. 2 in Amhara), including other types of physical assaults, property destruction, and denial of basic rights.

Takeaway: *Extrajudicial killings in Amhara, dominate alongside airstrikes, armed clashes, and widespread violations of liberty, revealing ongoing severe human rights abuses in both regions.*

ALLEGED PERPETRATORS

- Ethiopian Government Forces: Implicated in 50.00% (26 incidents), encompassing various state-aligned entities.
- Tigray Regional Forces/Police: 15.38% (8 incidents).
- Fano Militants: 11.54% (6 incidents).
- Eritrean Defense Forces: 5.77% (3 incidents).
- Other Unknown Armed Individuals/Group: 17.31% (9 cases), referring to unidentified armed groups or unknown gunmen.

Takeaway: *The Ethiopian government, entrusted with protecting civilians, is the principal perpetrator of atrocities, responsible for as many violations as all other actors combined.*

INCIDENT TYPE BY ALLEGED PERPETRATOR

- Ethiopian Government Forces: Frequently implicated in extrajudicial killings (8 incidents), airstrike-related incidents (1 incident), and other violations (6 incidents)
- Tigray Regional Forces/Police: Mainly associated with arbitrary arrests, detentions, and related abuses (4 incidents).
- Fano Militants: Linked to armed clashes/conflicts (3 incidents).
- Eritrean Defense Forces: Involved in abductions and disappearances (3 incidents).

Takeaway: *Ethiopian Government Forces are primarily responsible for extrajudicial killings.*

AFFECTED CIVILIAN GROUPS/VICTIMS

- Women, children & elderly: Most affected, 46.15% (24 incidents).
- Civilians (General): 25.00% (13 incidents), including students, young men, and community members.
- Religious figures: 9.62% (5 incidents).
- Health professionals: 7.69% (4 incidents).
- Farmers: 5.77% (3 incidents).
- Journalists/media professionals: 3.85% (2 incidents).
- IDPs/Displaced: 1.92% (1 incident).

Takeaway: *No section of society is immune to human rights violations in Ethiopia, but women, children, and the elderly bear the greatest burden.*

AFFECTED VULNERABLE GROUPS BY ALLEGED PERPETRATOR

- Ethiopian Government Forces: Disproportionately affect Civilians (9 incidents) and Women, Children & Elderly (2 incidents).
- Eritrean Defense Forces (EDF): Linked to Women, Children & Elderly (1 incident) and Men (1 incident), often via abductions.
- Fano Militants: Affected Civilians (General) (1 incident) and Journalists/Media Professionals (1 incident).
- Other/Unknown Perpetrators: Significant impact on Other/Not Specified groups (8 incidents), including ethnic-specific and youth-related impacts.

Takeaway: *The Ethiopian Government Forces predominantly target civilians and vulnerable groups, while the Eritrean Defense Forces engage in abductions often affecting women, children, and men, and other armed groups impact diverse community members including journalists and ethnic youth.*

OJAH has found that rights defenders, investigators, and activists are among the victims and survivors of human rights violations in Ethiopia.

- Incident TG001/01/2025 involved intimidation and detention of two Tigray Television journalists during an interview on environmental contamination.
- Incident AM410/06/2025 involved an airstrike killing an Ethiopian news agency cameraman and injuring a photographer, highlighting dangers to reporting.
- Incident AM406/02/2025 involved the killing of a medical specialist and hospital director.

- Incidents AM407/05/2025 and AM007/05/2025 involved arbitrary detention and alleged torture of health professionals linked to protests or strikes.
- Incident AM018/04/2025 involved the killing of another medical professional, showing targeting that hinders humanitarian services and human rights monitoring.

Takeaway: *Human rights defenders, journalists, and medical professionals in Ethiopia face intimidation, arbitrary detention, torture, and killings, severely obstructing humanitarian efforts and independent reporting in conflict zones.*

CONCLUSION: THE LEAP OF INSIGHT

OJAH's findings reveal persistent and prevalent patterns of systematic violence across the Amhara and Tigray regions in Ethiopia. Despite shifts in incident frequency across regions, there is no indication of lessening in atrocities. The Ethiopian government stands out as the prime perpetrator of violence, accounting for half of all documented incidents. This clearly indicates the urgency for a determined effort on the part of organizations working on human rights to put combined pressure on the government to confront impunity in Ethiopia.

Children, women, and the elderly bear the heaviest toll. Rights defenders, journalists, and health professionals face intimidation, arbitrary detention, and killings, which severely undermine humanitarian operations and independent monitoring. The International community should break its silence and be voice for the voiceless.

The data highlight the urgent need for accountability, enhanced protection of civilians, and sustained international attention to pressure the Ethiopian government, institutions, and the different actors that violate human rights to stop atrocities and guarantee justice and accountability.

ROADMAP FOR JUSTICE: ACTIONABLE RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on the information collected and patterns identified in this pilot monitoring project, OJAH presents the following urgent recommendations for all stakeholders:

TO HUMAN RIGHTS ADVOCACY ORGANIZATIONS AND CIVIL SOCIETY

1. **Unify and Coordinate Actions of Human Rights Organizations:** We call the attention of all organizations working to bring justice and accountability in Ethiopia to the fact that their fragmented efforts are severely hindering results. Thus, OJAH proposes to take the initiative to lead this coordination and calls upon all parties involved to join arms with OJAH in forming a Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations outside the radius of the government control to build a unified and effective front for justice and accountability in Ethiopia.

2. **Victim-Centered Justice:** The Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations should advocate for a comprehensive transitional justice process that is victim-centered, inclusive, and independently monitored, ensuring that any framework addresses truth-telling, reparations, and preventing future violence as top priorities.
3. **Apply All Avenues to Guarantee Justice and Accountability:** The Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations should put pressure on the Ethiopian government for the immediate enactment of the National Transitional Justice Mechanism and also explore other alternative avenues to guarantee justice and accountability, which may include the International Commission of Human Rights Experts on Ethiopia; United Nations Special Rapporteurs and Experts; UN Human Rights Council Investigative Mechanisms; African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights (ACHPR); African Court on Human and Peoples' Rights (AfCHPR); East African Court of Justice (EACJ); Hybrid or Special Courts; National Independent Investigative and Prosecution Bodies; Civil Society and Human Rights Organizations; Universal Jurisdiction by Other States; International Arbitration and Fact-Finding Missions; and the International Criminal Court (ICC).

TO THE INTERNATIONAL COMMUNITY (POLICY MAKERS & DIPLOMATIC BODIES)

4. **Technical and Financial Support towards Unity among Human Rights Defenders:** OJAH calls upon international partners to extend technical and financial support to expedite the process of the formation of a Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations outside the radar of the government control to spearhead a unified force against impunity in Ethiopia.
5. **Conditioned Engagement:** Impose robust, targeted sanctions on individuals and entities responsible for grave violations in Ethiopia and condition all non-humanitarian aid and diplomatic engagement on verifiable, substantive improvements in human rights protection.

TO ETHIOPIAN JUSTICE AND SECURITY INSTITUTIONS AND PERPETRATORS OF VIOLENCE

6. **End Human Rights Violations:** OJAH demand an immediate release of all unlawfully detained individuals in Ethiopia and insist on detention being conducted strictly in accordance with the law, guaranteeing prompt review by an independent authority, and ensuring access to legal support and family communication.
7. **Call for Protection for Defenders of Human Rights in Ethiopia:** We demand that the Ethiopian government end harassment, threats, and targeting human rights defenders, journalists, and medical staff for their efforts to ensure justice and accountability.
8. **Call to stop violence:** We demand that the Ethiopian government and all parties involved, including Tigray Regional Forces/Police; Fano Militants; Eritrean Defense Forces; and armed individuals/groups stop violating human rights.